

equaliser lights. It makes you feel as if you are in a party environment. Snag this one from www.winamp.com/plugins.

Reproduction Control 1.28

If you frequently use Winamp and find it difficult to shuttle back and forth between windows to open files, reduce the volume or skip a track (or any of those basic functionalities), Reproduction Control is the answer to your prayers. You can control your Winamp with customised shortcuts that you can use even when you are not in the Winamp window. For instance, you can increase or decrease the volume in Winamp by tapping your customised hot key even while working on a Word document. Lift it from www.winamp.com/plugin-ins.

Voluptuous Valentine's dancer

Tired of seeing the same beat up visualisation options? Give yourself a visual treat with WildTangent's Valentine's dancer. The valentine dancer



Valentine's dancer: it swings to your tune

swings to the beat of the music and will remain a novelty for some time. Pick it up from www.wildtangent.com

Creating your own Skins for Winamp

One of the winning points of Winamp is its customisability. A vast community of users has created numerous input, output and visualisation plugins.

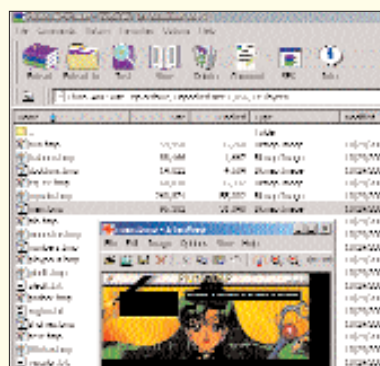
Tools for some Winamp skinning

Making your own skin for Winamp is pretty easy. But before you get down and stick your elbows in the dirt, here's a list of programs you need:

- A paint program such as Photoshop or Paint Shop Pro or MS Paint
- Winamp's base skin to use as a template.
- A text editor to configure the fonts and colours of the browser and playlist editor. Notepad will work just fine.
- An icon editor such as Icon Edit Pro or Microangelo if you want to edit the cursors and pointers for your skin.
- A compression tool to browse through skins and zip it all up when it's done—WinZip for instance.

Start at the base

The .wsz base skin is a Zip file designed to keep all the pieces of the skin organised. Every skin that's made is open source. You can browse through it to look for design tips. The best way to get started is to



The .wsz file will open in any unarchiving utility. Here's the framework of the main window in Winamp

extract a base skin and modify it. Create a new directory in your Winamp\Skins directory. Create a new folder in your Skins directory, and unzip the Winamp base skin with an unzip utility. Once you've installed the base skin, you can look at the files in that directory. There should be a whole bunch of .cur (cursor) files, and .bmp files, and a few .txt files. All of these files are optional. Any missing files will use Winamp's defaults.

Editing the skin

Editing the BMP files is a bit complex. The filenames are self-explanatory, but if you belong to the echelons of the uninitiated then,

- Pledit.bmp changes the look of the Playlist Editor
- Eqmain.bmp changes the look of the graphical equalizer
- Main.bmp changes the look of the main window

All the other .bmp files change the look of individual controls of the main interface. Once you've made changes to the different

BMP files, zip them up and hit [F5] in Winamp to reload the images.

Editing the text files

You can change other aspects of Winamp using the three .txt files included in the skin.

- Pledit.txt changes the font and colour of the playlist text.

- Viscolor.txt has 24 lines, with each line consisting of a RGB triplet and a comment: 24,33,41, // comment. These 24 lines define the colours used in Winamp's built-in visualisation. Region.txt lets you specify a sub-region of Winamp's main and equaliser windows to show. This lets you carve out the parts you want to show, and keep the rest transparent.

Editing cursors

The filenames for the cursor files are also pretty self-explanatory.

- EQTitle.cur is for the EQ's title bar.
- Normal.cur is for use in Winamp's main window.
- PWSSize.cur means that this cursor is for the Playlist Editor.

If you have any doubt, you can just try making a major change to check where the change takes effect. Cursor changes happen immediately; there's no need to reload the current skin in Winamp to see them.



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